

Christ Alone Head Of Church

doc-christ-alone-head-of-church
Ecclesiology · Nature of the Church · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

breadth broad
directness direct
variants stable

Statement under examination

Christ alone is the Head of the Church; no human being holds that office or shares that authority.

In plain language

Five passages drive this proposition, and they all use the same Greek word for head or source (kephale). In Ephesians 1:22 God gives Christ as head over all things to the church (assembly or church, ekklesia). In Ephesians 4:15 the head is named plainly as Christ. In Ephesians 5:23 Christ is head of the church, the savior of the body. In Colossians 1:18 he himself (autos) is the head of the body, the church, and the rare verb to hold first place (proteuo), which appears only once in the whole canon (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), says that in everything he himself holds first place. Colossians 2:10 calls him head of all rule and authority, and Colossians 2:19 says the whole body grows only by holding fast (krateo) to the head, who supplies and knits it together. In each case the subject is singular, the verb is 'is' (the linking verb 'is'), and the intensive pronoun he himself (autos) points back to one person, Christ. A search of all seventy-six places the word head (kephale) occurs is telling: head and church land in the same verse only three times, and every one of them names Christ. The word is never attached to any human in relation to the church. The positive half of the claim, that Christ is the one head, is therefore stated outright. The negative half, that no human holds or shares the office, follows from the grammar and from that empty slot. There is one honest word-level debate. The word head (kephale) can mean authority over someone or it can mean source and origin, and 1 Corinthians 11:3 uses it to order persons rather than to describe the church. But on either sense the head of the church is still Christ, and even there the highest head named is God and Christ, never a human. Leaders such as elders and the gifted roles in Ephesians 4 work inside the body and are never called its head, which is a different category. So the lexical pattern strongly supports a single head. The support is dense and grammatically tight but sits within two letters rather than spanning the whole canon, so it is decisive yet local.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0746	ἀρχή	arche	beginning	58
G0846	αὐτός	autos	it/s/he	5,909
G1510	εἰμί	eimi	to be	
G1577	ἐκκλησία	ekklesia	assembly	119
G2776	κεφαλή	kephale	head	76
G2902	κρατέω	krateo	to grasp/seize	48
G4138	πλήρωμα	pleroma	fulfillment	19
G4409	πρωτεύω	proteuo	be first	1

G4416	πρωτότοκος	prototokos	firstborn	8
G4983	σῶμα	soma	body	144
G5293	ὑποτάσσω	hypotasso	to subject	44
G5547	Χριστός	Christos	Christ	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

The noun 'head or source' (kephale, G2776) is predicated of Christ in relation to the body and the 'assembly or church' (ekklesia, G1577) five times across two letters: Ephesians 1:22 (God gave him, 'head' (kephalen) in the accusative form (the 'direct object' grammatical form), as head over all things to the church), Ephesians 4:15 (the head (he kephale), Christ (Christos)), Ephesians 5:23 (head or source (kephale) of the church, a predicate nominative (a noun completing a 'X is Y' statement) anchored to Christ (Christos) by name), Colossians 1:18 (he himself is the head (autos estin he kephale) of the body, the church), and Colossians 2:10 (the head or source (he kephale) of all rule and authority). Each predication uses a singular subject, and in Colossians 1:18 and Ephesians 5:23 the intensive nominative pronoun 'he himself' (autos, G0846, P-NSM) with the present copula (the linking verb 'is') 'is' (estin, V-PAI-3S, present indicative third person singular, that is an ongoing simple statement of fact). Colossians 1:18 adds the canon hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) 'to hold first place' (proteuo, G4409, V-PAP-NSM), so that he himself might hold first place, and Colossians 2:19 makes the head the single source from which the whole body grows. A direct concordance of all 76 occurrences of 'head or source' (kephale) shows that 'head or source' (kephale) and 'assembly or church' (ekklesia) co-occur in only three verses, and in all three the head is Christ; the lexeme is never attached to a human over the church. The negative half of the proposition is therefore a sound inference from the singular and intensive grammar plus the empty co-referent slot (no other candidate ever fills that head-slot), not a separate lexeme.

Scripture

Eph.1.22 · **for** · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2776 κεφαλή, G1577 ἐκκλησία, G0846 αὐτός, G5293 ὑποτάσσω

Force. God subjected ('he subjected', hypetaxen, G5293, aorist, that is a completed past action) all things under his feet and gave him ('him', auton, in the accusative singular masculine form, that is the 'direct object' singular masculine form) as head ('head', kephalen, N-ASF, the noun in direct-object singular feminine form) over all things to the church. The church is the recipient of an appointed single head, never a co-head. The direct-object form 'head' (kephalen) with the singular pronoun fixes one head given to the 'assembly or church' (ekklesia).

Eph.4.15 · **for** · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2776 κεφαλή, G5547 Χριστός

Force. Growing up in all things into him who is the head, namely Christ (the head, he kephale, Christ, Christos). The head is named explicitly as Christ and is the goal of the body's growth, matching the head-body source language of Colossians 2:19. No second head is named.

Eph.5.23 · **for** · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor, simile

Key terms. G2776 κεφαλή, G1577 ἐκκλησία, G5547 Χριστός

Force. Christ is head ('head or source', kephale, N-NSF, the noun in singular feminine subject form, functioning as a predicate nominative, that is a noun completing a 'X is Y' statement) of the church, he himself savior of the body, set in parallel with the husband as head of the wife. The predicate nominative 'head or source' (kephale) is anchored to Christ (Christos) by name, fixing the single referent of the headship over the 'assembly or church' (ekklesia).

Col.1.18 · **for** · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2776 κεφαλή, G4983 σῶμα, G4409 πρωτεύω, G0846 αὐτός

Force. And he himself is the head of the body, the church ('he himself', autos, P-NSM, intensive singular masculine pronoun; 'is', estin, V-PAI-3S, present indicative third person singular, that is an ongoing simple statement of fact; 'the head or source', he kephale, N-NSF, singular feminine subject form), so that in everything he himself might hold first place. The intensive 'he himself' (autos) plus the canon hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) 'to hold first place' (proteuo, G4409) lexically encodes sole preeminence (meaning first-place ranking is fixed in the vocabulary itself) and leaves no grammatical slot for a shared or human head.

Col.2.10 · **for** · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2776 κεφαλή, G0746 ἀρχή

Force. Christ is the head ('the head or source', he kephale) of all rule ('rule' or 'beginning', arche, G0746) and authority. The same headship lexeme places Christ over every governing power, so the headship language is not a narrow office but a comprehensive supremacy (meaning a top rank that covers everything) that no created authority shares.

Col.2.19 · **for** · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2776 κεφαλή, G2902 κρατέω, G4983 σῶμα

Force. Not holding fast ('to hold fast', kratio, G2902) the head, from whom the whole body, supplied and knit together, grows with the growth of God. The head is the single source of supply and cohesion for the body, so failure is defined as not holding the one head rather than choosing among heads.

1Cor.11.3 · **complicates** · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2776 κεφαλή

Force. The man is head of the woman, Christ is head of the man, and God is head of Christ. Here 'head or source' (kephale) orders persons within a relational chain, showing the lexeme (the dictionary word) can carry the sense of authority over or alternatively source or origin. This is a different object than the church, and even here the highest head named is God and Christ, never a human over the 'assembly or church' (ekklesia).

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Col.1.18	Eph.1.22	openbible	43
Col.1.18	Rev.1.5	openbible	38
Col.1.18	Eph.4.15	openbible	21
Eph.1.22	Col.2.10	openbible	15
Eph.1.22	1Cor.15.25	openbible	13
Col.1.18	Ps.89.27	openbible	14
Eph.1.22	Ps.8.6	openbible	9
Eph.5.23	1Cor.11.3	openbible	14
Col.2.19	Eph.4.15	openbible	17
Col.1.18	Ps.45.2	tsk	1

Complicating texts

1Cor.11.3 · addressed

Here 'head or source' (kephale) appears in a chain naming the man as head of the woman and God as head of Christ, which shows the lexeme (the dictionary word) can carry relational ordering and is read by some as authority over and by others as source or origin. This does not weaken the church verses, because the object in Ephesians and Colossians is the 'assembly or church' (ekklesia) and the body, and a direct concordance shows 'head or source' (kephale) and 'assembly or church' (ekklesia) co-occur in only three verses, all of which name Christ. No human is ever set as head of the church with this lexeme.

Eph.4.11 · addressed

The list of apostles, prophets, evangelists, shepherds, and teachers names gifted human roles for equipping the body, but the grammar keeps these as functions given by the ascended Christ, not as 'head or source' (kephale) of the church. The lexeme 'head or source' (kephale) is never applied to any of these offices, so they are leaders within the body, a different category than the one head over it, and do not compete with Ephesians 1:22, Ephesians 5:23, and Colossians 1:18.

Acts.4.11 · addressed

Here 'head or source' (kephale) appears in the fixed idiom 'head of the corner', the cornerstone, also at 1 Peter 2:7 and the Synoptic citations of Psalm 118. That is a stone metaphor for chief or capstone, a third attested sense of 'head or source' (kephale) alongside anatomical head and headship of the body. It still lands on Christ and supplies no human head of the church, so it does not disturb the verdict.

Concordance traversed

G2776, G1577, G4983, G0846, G4409, G2902, G0746, G4416, G5293, G4138, G1510

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No variant units (places where ancient manuscripts disagree on wording) were supplied for the Ephesians or Colossians anchors, and the bundle marks these outside published ECM apparatus (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) scope, so this is shadow status only (the variant data was not fully audited). The marked points in the bundle text at Ephesians 5:23 and Colossians 1:18 touch word order and the presence of 'is' (estin), neither of which alters the predication of 'head or source' (kephale) to Christ over the 'assembly or church' (ekklesia), since the predicate nominative (a noun completing a 'X is Y' statement) and the intensive 'he himself' (autos) remain stable.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

analogia scripturae invoked

kephale as authority-over: affirms · Reads 'head or source' (kephale) in the church verses as ruling authority, so that the singular 'he himself' (autos) plus singular 'head or source' (kephale) plus the hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) 'to hold first place' (proteuo) fix Christ as the one ruling head with no shared office. The negative half follows directly, because no human is ever named ruling head of the church.

kephale as source or origin: affirms · Reads 'head or source' (kephale) primarily as source or fountainhead, drawing on Colossians 2:19 where the whole body grows and is supplied from the head. Even on this reading the proposition still holds, because the church is sourced from Christ alone and no human is named as the source from which the body grows. Both attested senses of the word converge on Christ as the single head.

delegated human leadership within the body: compatible, not a competing head · Notes that elders, overseers, and the gifts of Ephesians 4:11 lead within the body. Read fairly, this is not a rival to the verdict, because the texts assign these their authority as gifts given by the head and never call any of them 'head or source' (kephale) of the church. They are leaders within, not the head over, so the single-head claim and ordinary human leadership are different categories that do not conflict.

The verdict turns on the grammar of the head-body metaphor read across Ephesians and Colossians by analogy of Scripture (the principle that Scripture interprets Scripture). The one genuine lexical debate, whether 'head or source' (kephale) means authority over or source, does not move the verdict, because on either sense the head of the church is Christ alone. The negative half of the proposition is inferred from the singular and intensive constructions and the empty co-referent slot (no other candidate ever fills that head-slot).

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Examine how the lexeme (the dictionary word) 'head or source' (kephale) is predicated of Christ in relation to the church and the body, and whether the grammar identifies one head or admits an additional or human head.

The stem carries an exclusivity frame in the words 'alone' and 'no human being holds that office or shares that authority'. The positive identification of Christ as 'head or source' (kephale) of the 'assembly or church' (ekklesia) and the body is explicit in Ephesians 1:22, Ephesians 4:15, Ephesians 5:23, Colossians 1:18, and Colossians 2:10. The negative exclusion of human headship is an inference from the singular subject, the intensive 'he himself' (autos), and a concordance showing 'head or source' (kephale) and 'assembly or church' (ekklesia) co-occur in only three verses, all naming Christ, rather than from a separate lexeme. The verdict was derived on the original stem, and the inference is judged sound because the lexeme is never applied to a human over the church.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Col.1.18
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Eph.1.22
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2776
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4409
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Eph.5.23
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Col.2.19
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Col.1.18
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Eph.1.22
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Col.1.18

License audit

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